

IN CONVERSATION WITH AMIT KALRA, HEAD, GBS CENTERS, INDIA

Please can you share a brief history about Swiss Re GBS India? How does it help in achieving Swiss Re's overall business objectives?

For over 160 years, Swiss Re has been committed to driving resilience for the world. We started our journey in India more than 20 years ago with the establishment of Swiss Re Global Business Solutions (GBS) India in Bangalore. It is now one of Swiss Re's largest Global Capability Centre, with close to 2000 employees.

We have recently expanded our footprint in India further with a new base in Hyderabad. Our team includes incredibly talented engineers, actuaries, underwriting analysts, analysts, R&D and technical experts, and others. Our multigeneration workforce combined with our decades-worth wealth of experience has ensured that we possess all the necessary skills and capabilities across the value chain, which uniquely positions GBS India as a center of excellence for the Swiss Re group.

Swiss Re is focused on building resilient communities, how does your team enable this?

At Swiss Re GBS India, we have teams of experts in every domain pertaining to business, finance, and technology, who support Swiss Re developing innovative solutions for building resilient communities. On the corporate side, we have helped develop a platform called 'Risk Data & Services,' which allows companies to create digital twins of their assets to improve risk modelling. Magnum (Swiss Re's underwriting automation solution) has been developed for over 20 years. On the social and environmental front, we support on engineering solutions that leverage satellite imaging and AI-powered predictive tools to mitigate flood risk and rapidly assess damage. Swiss Re also has a flagship entrepreneurship programme called the Shine Accelerator which is aimed at supporting the next generation of social innovators in India.

The Shine Accelerator sounds interesting, can you share a little more about it and how it has impacted the community?

Shine is Swiss Re's transformative leadership development program aimed at fostering innovations that build societal resilience in India. It is open to all early-stage social entrepreneurs. We collaborate with startups to create impact in areas such as the transition to net zero; climate-smart agriculture; disaster risk reduction; and access to health and nutrition. One of the salient features of this programme is that Swiss Re business experts and leaders' partner with social innovators during their crucial growth phase and guide them in transforming their promising solutions into scalable business models.

So far, Swiss Re GBS India has supported startups like Pure Paani, which is dedicated to making drinking water available to all; Bee Basket, which extracts pure honey without destroying beehives; Sunbird Straws, which is making the world's first premium multi-layered straws from naturally dried coconut leaves; Hydro Green Fodder, which provides high-protein hydroponic fodder options that are natural, palatable, digestible, and good for livestock; and Carbon Craft, which is developing carbon upcycling products for the world's construction demands to mitigate air pollution at scale.

What are some initiatives that Swiss Re GBS India implements to engage with employees and foster a culture of belongingness?

We invest time and effort in engaging with our employees and creating a culture of innovation, inclusion, belongingness, and fun. At GBS India, we have various initiatives that help us keep the focus on gender diversity. Our overall gender diversity has constantly been on the rise since 2019 from 37% to 42% in 2023. We have segmented programs that help create a leadership pipeline at every band with a fair gender representation. All this has been made possible by our inclusion-first approach to DEI and ensuring that we are consistent and sustainable, leaving nothing to chance.

We are especially proud of the 'Agilympics' initiative that we launched in 2020. It is a first-of-its-kind, fun-filled Olympic-themed competition that has blends fun with educational sessions to provide insights into agile concepts. We engage with our employees



regularly through activities such as Family Carnival Day, Food Festivals, Vegan Day, and cultural days.

We have also partnered with various NGOs where our employees volunteer for social causes. Last year, we organized a five-kilometer marathon under the Giving@Swiss Re initiative for our employees, where, with the completion of every 5 km of walking or running, one child from an underserved community would get access to mid-day meals for an entire year in school. In our very first Giving@SwissRe initiative in Hyderabad, 25 of our colleagues travelled more than 30 km into the city's suburbs to support Akshaya Patra, a charity organization, where they interacted with more than 160 kids and distributed stationery kits and mid-day meals.

Cognizant of the importance of physical exercise, we place a lot of emphasis on sports – both indoors and outdoors – to help our employees stay active and overcome work-related fatigue.

What is the achievement of Swiss Re GBS you are most proud of?

Swiss Re GBS India has transformed from a shared services center to a global capability centre providing employment to a diverse set of professionals from finance to technology. This entire journey of scaling up from around 50-member team to having 2 capability centres, with close to 2000 India is something that is special to all of us. Over the last few years, we have repositioned ourselves tech enablement center, by strengthening our data and digital capabilities. Supporting in modelling expertise and developing new data-driven services, we assist Swiss Re in predicting and mitigating risk before an unforeseen event happens.

Additionally, Swiss Re has teams of actuaries across the different lines of business who support in Modelling to Valuation, Pricing, Costing, Reserving, Reporting & Analysis. Our CoE (Centre of Excellence) ambition drives us towards continuously enhancing our capabilities in scale, depth, and scope of work, with a focus on business priorities and must wins. We do this with a strong alignment with our Business Units and Global functions in a 'One Global Team' mindset.

Your Hyderabad office completes one year, how has the journey been so far?

It has been a great year for Swiss Re GBS India and of, course, for our Hyderabad office. We grew our function capabilities and added more than a hundred people to our team in Hyderabad in quick time, with capabilities spanning Cloud Engineering, Data Architecture, Data Science, and Analytics. We also created niche skill sets such as Chapter Product Area Management, Solution Governance and Operations, Solutions Product Development and Management, Product Management, and Technology Management.

In addition to our business accomplishments, we partnered with T-Hub to be part of world's largest innovation campus. We have also collaborated with the Institute of Insurance and Risk Management in Hyderabad to strengthen re/insurance academics in India. We will continue to invest in technology, infrastructure, and talent to enhance our capabilities.